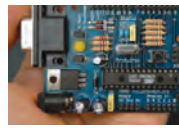


## The Beagleboard

The Beagleboard is a fanless single board computer using ARM processors that has all the capabilities of a modern desktop. More info at [beagleboard.org](http://beagleboard.org)



## Arduino

The Arduino is a very popular prototyping platform for making small devices that interface with computers, and is the most modded pieces of open source hardware

# The Folks behind FOSS

The Free and Open Source Software (FOSS) movement proposes a drastically different licensing approach for software, and how they are used. For a lay person, there might not be much difference between using a FOSS software, or a commercial alternative, as long as the software gets the work done. One of the fundamental features of the FOSS movement is the people who drive it. FOSS is driven by the contribution and the collaboration of the likes of the individuals featured here

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## Raghavendra S

Raghavendra S is actively involved with the Free Software Movement-Karnataka (FSMK, <http://fsmk.org/>), where a group of volunteers reach out mainly to students, trying to increase their awareness about FOSS and its benefits, by conducting talks and workshops pertaining to FOSS. FSMK also conducts workshops for school teachers and promotes regional use of GNU/Linux by involving themselves in localising a Debian release to the regional language, Kannada, released as Namma Debian, which means "Our Debian" in Kannada. Raghavendra S contributes to this movement by volunteering for most of the events organized by FSMK on a regular basis. He chronicles the activities of FSMK at his blog, which is hosted at <http://ideasareimmortal.blogspot.com>.

We asked him how interested people could help out. His answer shows that you do not need to code or actually make software to be actively involved in FOSS. "The Internet with its enormous and amicable FOSS community is the way to go for a newbie. Another approachable avenue is forums like FSMK, where we involve newbies in various FOSS related events continuously. In this process they

learn all the essentials of being a FOSS enthusiast. (I am one such student turned FOSS activist from FSMK). There are many organizations like FSMK in almost all states in India to seek mentoring from." We also asked him why the FOSS movement was important to him; his answer has some valuable insights on why the FOSS movement is so important, especially in India. "Free and Open Source Software is important to me at two levels - at a personal level and at a national level as well. Personally because, FOSS is more humane, by which I point to its fundamental attribute of 'sharing and growing together' - the essence of human beings. At a national level, it gains a substantial economic dimension as well: In developing countries, we cannot afford to buy proprietary software to run the country, shelling out huge amounts of money to few monopolies. FOSS offers almost free solution to all our computing needs, with the freedom of owning the software as well, rather than licensing it intermittently. Another important aspect is the scope for small scale entrepreneurial opportunities FOSS provides to bubbling techies." Raghavendra S has also identified an area where young people can contribute meaningfully, "I coordinate the Debian localisation project and we have the aim of

taking the benefits of free software technology to the last man and woman in the villages. This requires a lot of volunteer based man power for the tasks of translating the user interface to Kannada, training students and teachers in using these tools, helping out in educational projects involving under-privileged kids."

## Akshay Bajaj

Akshay Bajaj is the founder and CEO of Net4uonline.com. He is one of the many people who has built a business around the FOSS movement. Net4uonline is building India's first hand held touchscreen wikipedia reader - a pocket sized device that contains the entire wikipedia encyclopedia in it.

We asked Akshay Bajaj what is perhaps the most important questions about FOSS, how a viable commercial revenue model can be built around the FOSS movement, and he does not think it is too hard. "The same as other service oriented businesses! Since the software (and its code) is free and open, most business models are built around offering services to enable end users (clients) to efficiently implement an open source solution. The FOSS landscape can be especially daunting to most companies (and end users) owing to the vast number of options available for any kind of solution. A quick look at [sourceforge.net](http://sourceforge.net) will indicate the vastness and complexity of the FOSS landscape. This complexity combined with the unstructured (and sometimes slightly chaotic) development lifecycles and broken support of open source projects, provides an excellent business opportunity to open source businesses. A point worth remembering, is that source code on its own has very little value, instead the required technological expertise, ability to maintain and enhance it that carries the most value and thus brings commercial viability to the open source business model."

Akshay, like other FOSS enthusiasts, advocates it because "if you can think it, you can do it!"